

The Money Texts We Have Learned Not to See

Scripture speaks about wealth and the poor with a frequency our preaching has never matched. Both parties found a way to keep the texts and lose the cost.

THE COUNT

A Subject We Cannot Avoid, Avoided

Open a concordance and count. Scripture returns to money, possessions, and the poor hundreds of times, by most counts more often than it speaks of heaven and hell combined. Jesus talked about wealth more than almost any other moral subject. A large share of his parables touch money. The Torah legislates it. The prophets rage over it. The epistles warn about it in their closing chapters like a recurring emergency.

Now count the sermons. I can, because I preached them. In my first decade of ministry I preached the money texts at a rate that bore no relation to their frequency in the book I claimed as my authority. I was not censoring deliberately. I had simply learned, the way a child learns a dialect, which passages were for preaching and which were for footnotes. So has nearly every American congregation, red and blue alike.

Craig Blomberg's survey of the whole canon concludes that neither poverty nor riches is the biblical ideal, but that surplus sitting beside need is treated, page after page, as a spiritual crisis. We have learned not to see those pages. Both tribes did the unlearning, by different methods, and the methods are worth examining.

THE TORAH

Jubilee, Gleaning, and the Lord's Land

Israel's law built an economy for neighbors. Every seventh year, debts released, Deuteronomy 15. Every fiftieth, Jubilee: land returned to families so that no permanent underclass could form, liberty proclaimed throughout the land, Leviticus 25. Harvest edges left standing so the poor and the immigrant could glean with dignity, working rather than begging, Leviticus 19 and Deuteronomy 24. Wages paid before sundown. No interest charged on loans to the poor.

Christopher Wright insists this was not charity bolted onto an economy. It was the economy, a built structure of obligation, because the land was the Lord's and Israel were tenants on it. The whole system assumed what we deny: that my harvest is not entirely mine.

Then come the prophets, sent when the system was strangled by the people it inconvenienced. Amos on the cows of Bashan and the scales rigged against the needy. Isaiah on those who join house to house and field to field until no room remains. Isaiah 58 on the fast God refuses while workers go unpaid. The charge was almost never that Israel had stopped believing. It was that Israel kept worshiping while the gleaning fields quietly disappeared. The liturgy survived the obedience. It usually does.

THE GOSPELS

Luke's Woes and James's Howl

The New Testament does not soften any of this. Luke's Jesus blesses the poor and then turns to the other side of the crowd: woe to you who are rich, for you have received your consolation. He tells of a rich fool whose new barns outlived him by one night, and of a rich man whose only recorded crime was stepping over Lazarus at his gate until the day they both died. Zacchaeus is saved and half his goods leave the house that same afternoon, and Jesus calls the giving the evidence of the salvation, not its price.

James writes to Christian congregations the way Amos wrote to Samaria: come now, you rich, weep and howl. The wages you withheld are crying out, and the cries have reached the ears of the Lord of hosts. Paul tells Timothy that those who desire to be rich fall into a snare, and then instructs the wealthy, note that he assumes the church contains them, to be rich in good works and generous instead.

None of these texts is obscure. Every one of them sits in the lectionary. We have all read them, recently, and they have cost most of us, me included, almost nothing. That fact requires an explanation.

THE EVASIONS

Spiritualize or Outsource

The explanation is that American Christians built two escape routes, one per party, and both work.

The right spiritualizes. Blessed are the poor in spirit, the reading goes, so the poverty texts are about humility. Jubilee is fulfilled in Christ, so it asks nothing of my ledger. The rich young ruler was a special case, his problem was attachment, and since I judge my own heart unattached, I may keep everything. Money becomes a heart issue, and the heart, conveniently, is invisible.

The left outsources. The texts are about systems, so my obligation is a policy preference. I advocate the right programs, vote the right way, and the state does my gleaning for me, while my own giving sits, the surveys keep finding, at roughly the same low percentage as my conservative neighbor's. Compassion becomes a position, and positions are free.

Both moves are built from real truths, which is why they work. Wealth is a heart issue. Justice does involve systems. But watch the outcome. In both cases the text is affirmed and the wallet is untouched. Two theologies, one bank statement. I have preached the first escape and voted the second, and neither one ever asked me for a key to the house.

THE DEMAND

A Person, a Congregation, a Ledger

What do the money texts actually ask?

Of a person: that giving be proportionate, planned, and felt. Zacchaeus set a number out loud. The Macedonian churches gave beyond their means and Paul praised them for it rather than correcting them. Tim Keller argues from these texts that generosity in Scripture is not a tip added to a comfortable life but a structural feature of a converted one. So the honest question is not whether I give. It is whether my giving has ever altered how I live, and for most of my ministry the answer was no.

Of a congregation: that the church be the first economy where Jubilee is visible. Acts reports that there was no needy person among them, an echo of Deuteronomy 15 that Luke surely intended. A church budget is a confession of faith. So is a personal one. Mine confessed, for years, that I believed in Jesus and trusted the mortgage.

The texts will not be argued away. They can only be obeyed or avoided, and we have grown skilled at avoidance, left and right, each tribe watching the other's hypocrisy with perfect vision. Somewhere in your city tonight is a Lazarus whose name God knows. The text is waiting to find out whether you do.

KEY TEXTS

Leviticus 25:8-17

Luke 6:20-26

James 5:1-6

SOURCES

Generous Justice: How God's Grace Makes Us Just — Timothy Keller

Neither Poverty nor Riches: A Biblical Theology of Possessions — Craig L. Blomberg

Old Testament Ethics for the People of God — Christopher J.H. Wright

Rich Christians in an Age of Hunger — Ronald J. Sider